# THE ROAD TO THE DECCAN

On a summer's day in 1594, Akbar stood by the banks of the river Ravi outside Lahore and witnessed a magnificent sight. A thousand men strained at ropes and pulleys and, finally, a huge ship, more than 90 feet long, lurched from the banks and into the river to the loud acclamation of all the onlookers. This ship, an ocean-going vessel, had taken the labour of 240 carpenters and ironsmiths, and had required almost 3,000 planks of wood—pine and sal—for its construction. After the sarkar of Thatta had become part of the empire with the annexation of Sind, Akbar decided to make use of its port, Bandar Lahiri. Since the region lacked good timber forests, the emperor had had the ingenious idea of building ships in Lahore, which was close to the Himalayan timber forests, and sailing the ships 650 miles south through the Indus river systems to Bandar Lahiri and into the ocean. On this occasion, the ship struggled in the waters of the Ravi, which were not deep enough for a seaworthy craft. So Akbar then devised the idea of an enormous barge upon which the next ship was loaded and floated down the river to the port. Once at the port, the barge was scuttled and the ship slipped easily into the sea. Through this contraption Akbar anticipated by a hundred years the 'camel' invented in the dockyards of the Netherlands in 1688, which was a submersible barge that floated ships over the shallows. This ship was to have been the first of a fleet of ocean-worthy ships—but as the Mughal court moved away from Lahore, these plans did not materialize. It is often believed that the Mughals had no interest in a navy but the large river fleet and the extraordinary experiment with this ship from Lahore show that this was not so.

Akbar's keen interest in new technology had led to a number of innovations, as we have seen, especially in gun-making, cannon, and water contraptions. This fascination was understood by all visitors, who strove to capture the Padshah's interest by presenting new, unusual things to him. When the Raja of Kumaon arrived at Lahore, much to Badauni's contempt, for 'he had never, nor his father or grandfather before him (God's curse be on them) seen an Emperor even in imagination', he brought animals from his hill country that amazed the Mughal courtiers. He brought a yak and a